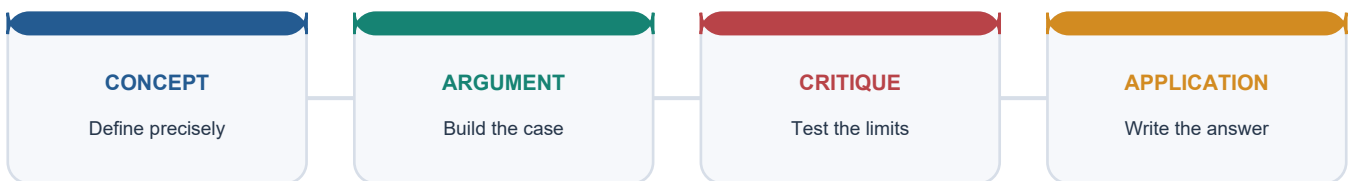


SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Mauryan, Buddhist, Jain and Rock-Cut Heritage - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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Mauryan, Buddhist, Jain and Rock-Cut Heritage - Solved Practice Workbook

This workbook is standalone: it carries the full 32-question MCQ set, direct and application PYQs, solved original Mains answers and drills on chronology, keywords and paragraph-building.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

CORE UPSC MCQS

Q1. Which statement best introduces Mauryan art without oversimplifying it?

A. Mauryan pillars and palaces clearly belong to court art, but royal dedications to Ajivika caves show that the court/popular distinction is a useful yet porous teaching device. B. Mauryan art can be divided permanently into Buddhist and non-Buddhist art. C. All Mauryan monuments were created outside state patronage. D. The court/popular distinction should be abandoned because no pattern exists at all.

Answer: A. Explanation: A is correct because it keeps the classification while immediately qualifying it with Barabar-Nagarjuni. B and C are factually wrong, and D throws away a useful opening framework instead of refining it.

Q2. Which sequence correctly preserves Sanchi's construction history?

A. Sunga brick core -> Mauryan gateways -> Gupta enlargement -> Satavahana toranas B. Mauryan brick core -> Sunga enlargement and stone facing -> Satavahana toranas -> Gupta additions C. Mauryan toranas -> Satavahana brick core -> Sunga shrines -> Gupta railing D. Gupta stupa core -> Mauryan pillar -> Sunga casing -> Satavahana decline

Answer: B. Explanation: B follows the safe phase order preserved in both Nitin and UNESCO. The other options reverse the phases or assign the wrong contribution to the wrong period.

Q3. Which site-feature pair is correctly matched?

A. Vaishali - four lions on a circular abacus with wheel carvings B. Sanchi pillar - single lion capital without abacus C. Sarnath - four lions back-to-back on an abacus with animal carvings and wheel symbolism D. Rampurva - only a bull capital and no lion capital

Answer: C. Explanation: C is the correct Sarnath description. Vaishali has a single lion without abacus, Sanchi has four lions with a flatter geese-and-palmette abacus, and Rampurva produced both lion and bull capitals.

Q4. What is the safest inference from the Barabar-Nagarjuni caves?

A. They prove that all Mauryan cave architecture was Buddhist. B. They show that mural painting was essential to the earliest rock-cut phase. C. They prove that Lomas Rishi was fully completed under Ashoka. D. They show that the earliest Indian rock-cut architecture combined royal patronage, Ajivika dedication and highly polished granite interiors.

Answer: D. Explanation: D joins the secure facts. A is false because the caves were for Ajivikas, B is false because no murals are reported, and C ignores Lomas Rishi's incompleteness.

Q5. Which statement about the stupa is correct?

A. The stupa tradition pre-dates Buddhism and later became a major relic and commemorative form in Buddhist practice. B. A stupa is exclusively Buddhist in origin and function. C. The torana is the summit umbrella of a stupa. D. Pradakshina patha refers to the relic casket inside the anda.

Answer: A. Explanation: A preserves both the origin qualifier and the later Buddhist role. B is the classic UPSC trap, while C and D confuse major stupa parts.

Q6. Which stupa part-function pair is correctly matched?

A. Harmika - ground-level ambulatory path B. Torana - ceremonial gateway carrying narrative or decorative emphasis C. Vedika - relic deposited inside the mound D. Chattra - stone railing around the lower terrace

Answer: B. Explanation: B is correct. Harmika is the summit railing, vedika marks the sacred boundary, and chattra is the honour-bearing umbrella form.

Q7. Which description most accurately captures a chaitya-griha?

A. A rock-cut royal palace with audience hall B. A free-standing structural temple with shikhara C. An apsidal prayer hall with a stupa focus, often using nave, aisles and a horseshoe facade window D. A monastic residence made only of wooden huts

Answer: C. Explanation: C gives the architectural and liturgical logic of the chaitya. The other options describe different building types or ignore rock-cut form.

Q8. Which site most clearly combines a two-phase Buddhist excavation history with unfinished caves that preserve the method of rock-cutting?

A. Sanchi B. Elephanta C. Bharhut D. Ajanta

Answer: D. Explanation: D is correct because UNESCO highlights Ajanta's two major phases and notes that the unfinished caves preserve the method of excavation. A is a layered stupa-hill complex rather than a cave-excavation sequence, B is a Shaiva-dominant island cave complex, and C is a stupa-railing site rather than a phased cave complex.

Q9. Which statement about Ajanta's phases is correct?

A. Ajanta preserves an early Satavahana-linked phase and a later Vakataka-era phase separated by several centuries. B. Ajanta is a single-period Rashtrakuta excavation. C. Ajanta contains only viharas and no chaityagrihas. D. Ajanta's historical value lies only in painting, not in architecture.

Answer: A. Explanation: A matches UNESCO's two-phase chronology. B, C and D each erase major parts of the site's evidentiary value.

Q10. Which line is the safest way to write Ellora's chronology?

A. All thirty-four caves were carved by one dynasty in one century. B. Ellora shows Buddhist, Brahmanical and Jain cave groups in a broad sequence from the 6th to the 12th century, but overlap and long use must still be kept visible. C. Ellora is only a Brahmanical site because Kailasha dominates it. D. Ellora's value lies only in sculpture, not in rock-cut planning.

Answer: B. Explanation: B preserves both sequence and qualification. The other options over-centralise one phase or erase the complexity of the site.

Q11. Which statement about Udayagiri near Vidisha is correct?

A. It is identical with Udayagiri-Khandagiri in Odisha. B. Its most important cave is a Buddhist chaitya hall of the Satavahana age. C. It was created in the early 5th century CE under Chandragupta II and is especially known for the Varaha relief and Gupta inscriptions. D. It is a Jain-only site with no Brahmanical imagery.

Answer: C. Explanation: C is the safe Udayagiri (Vidisha) description. A confuses two different sites, while B and D distort the site's Brahmanical-Gupta character.

Q12. Which use of Hathigumpha is best?

A. As proof that Kharavela narrated every important event in Kalinga's past B. As a decorative inscription with no historical value C. As evidence that Udayagiri-Khandagiri was a Buddhist cave complex D. As a major Prakrit-Brahmi narrative source for Kharavela that must still be read critically because royal inscriptions are selective

Answer: D. Explanation: D captures both its value and its limitation. The other options either overstate completeness or misidentify the site's Jain context.

Q13. Which statement about Elephanta is correct?

A. Elephanta is a Shaiva-dominant island cave complex on Gharapuri, with major Cave 1 and a famous Sadashiva/Trimurti image, while exact dynastic attribution remains debated. B. Elephanta is securely a Mauryan Buddhist cave group. C. Elephanta lies in the Waghora gorge. D. Elephanta has no Buddhist remains of any kind.

Answer: A. Explanation: A preserves location, religious emphasis, iconography and the attribution caution. The other options are plainly wrong.

Q14. Which statement about Amaravati is safest?

A. Amaravati was only a small relic mound with no sculptural or inscriptional value. B. Amaravati was a major Andhra Mahachaitya in the lower Krishna zone, enlarged under the Satavahanas and associated with limestone reliefs, Ayaka pillars and a long excavation-dispersal history. C. Amaravati stood in the Narmada gorge. D. Amaravati should be described as exactly 27 metres high without qualification.

Answer: B. Explanation: B keeps the lower-Krishna setting, patronage, material and afterlife together. C is geographically wrong, A strips the site of its importance, and D removes the necessary hedge from the measurement.

Q15. Which statement about Rampurva is correct?

A. Rampurva preserves only a lion capital with no bull comparison. B. Rampurva was a Gupta-period imitation of Ashokan pillar art. C. Two Ashokan pillars were found at Rampurva, one with a lion capital and one with a bull capital, but only the lion pillar carries the Major Pillar Edicts I-VI. D. Rampurva proves that every animal capital carried the same inscription.

Answer: C. Explanation: C is the exact safe formulation from the core evidence bank. The other options erase or distort the lion-bull functional difference.

Q16. Which claim about inscriptions is most defensible?

A. If a royal inscription is detailed, it can be treated as a neutral chronicle. B. Inscriptions are useful only for language history, not architecture. C. The omission of an event in an inscription proves the event never happened. D. Inscriptions can identify patrons, grants, sects, dates and sites, but genre, eulogy and silence must still be analysed.

Answer: D. Explanation: D reflects Upinder Singh's method and the topic's own use of Hathigumpha and the Baroda plate. The other options misuse silence or narrow the source unnecessarily.

Q17. Which statement best captures Jain architecture in this topic?

A. It runs from caves such as Udayagiri-Khandagiri and Ellora to temples, colossi and pilgrimage hills such as Dilwara, Ranakpur, Shravanabelagola and Shatrunjaya. B. It is confined to caves only. C. It has a completely separate formal vocabulary with no shared regional idioms. D. It begins only in the late medieval period.

Answer: A. Explanation: A gives the many-scale Jain programme. B, C and D are precisely the reductions the repaired package must avoid.

Q18. Which statement best avoids a common Jain-heritage trap in Topic 2?

A. Shravanabelagola's colossal image should be identified as Mahavira, the last tirthankara. B. Shravanabelagola's Bahubali colossus expands the topic beyond caves and should not be mislabeled as a tirthankara image. C. Jain architecture in this topic excludes hill-pilgrimage landscapes such as Shatrunjaya. D. Hathigumpha should be treated as a neutral Buddhist inscription.

Answer: B. Explanation: B is correct because the repaired topic explicitly uses Shravanabelagola to widen Jain heritage beyond caves and warns against mislabeling Bahubali as a tirthankara. A is wrong because Bahubali is not Mahavira, C is wrong because hill-pilgrimage landscapes are part of the Jain architectural programme, and D is wrong because Hathigumpha is a Jain-context royal inscription that still requires source criticism.

Q19. Which line is most careful on the aniconic-to-iconic transition?

A. Architecture alone explains the entire doctrinal shift from symbolism to image worship. B. Once Buddha images appear, stupas lose all importance. C. Early Buddhist art often represented the Buddha symbolically, while later image-centred programmes altered cave and shrine emphasis; architecture records this shift but does not solely cause it. D. Aniconic representation belongs only to Jain art.

Answer: C. Explanation: C keeps the shift visible without making architecture the sole cause. The other options exaggerate or misidentify the phenomenon.

Q20. Which conclusion best handles religious plurality at Ellora?

A. Ellora proves that all religious communities lived in total equality at one instant. B. Ellora is too complex to use in any answer. C. Ellora should be treated only as a sculpture site, not an architectural one. D. Ellora shows a shared sacred hillside used by Buddhist, Brahmanical and Jain communities across centuries, but the argument must preserve chronology and overlap rather than romanticise simultaneity.

Answer: D. Explanation: D is the repository's preferred conclusion. The others either romanticise or trivialise the site.

Q21. Which site-pillar detail is correctly identified?

A. Sanchi - Ashokan pillar with four lions, flatter abacus of geese and flame palmettes, plus Schism Edict B. Vaishali - four lions with wheel and animal abacus C. Sarnath - single lion without abacus D. Deur Kothar - no Buddhist association at all

Answer: A. Explanation: A is the safe Sanchi pillar description. The others shift Sarnath and Vaishali's features and ignore Deur Kothar's Buddhist relevance.

Q22. Which chronological order is correct?

A. Kailasha at Ellora -> Barabar caves -> Udayagiri Vidisha -> Ajanta early phase B. Barabar-Nagarjuni -> Ajanta early phase -> Udayagiri Vidisha -> Kailasha at Ellora C. Ajanta later phase -> Barabar caves -> Hathigumpha -> Sanchi core D. Udayagiri-Khandagiri -> Ashokan Sanchi -> Barabar -> Elephanta

Answer: B. Explanation: B moves from Mauryan earliest rock-cut to early Buddhist cave phase, then Gupta Udayagiri and finally Rashtrakuta Kailasha. The other sequences scramble the secure chronology.

Q23. Which site gives the sharpest evidence of early royal patronage of a non-Buddhist heterodox sect in rock-cut architecture?

A. Ajanta B. Elephanta C. Barabar-Nagarjuni D. Ellora

Answer: C. Explanation: Barabar-Nagarjuni is the clear Ajivika case and the strongest qualifier to simplistic readings of Ashokan patronage.

Q24. Which limitation sentence would most improve a 150-word answer on rock-cut architecture as a historical source?

A. Rock-cut monuments reveal everything about ordinary life in early India. B. Because caves survive, literary sources become unnecessary. C. Every surviving cave can be dated with complete certainty. D. Rock-cut monuments preserve durable patronage and ritual space very well, but they over-represent what was endowed in stone and must be read with inscriptions and other sources.

Answer: D. Explanation: D gives the precise limit that turns a descriptive answer into a high-quality source-critical answer.

Q25. Which statement about the Nasik caves is correct?

A. Nasik preserves 23 Buddhist caves, largely belonging to the Hinayana period but later showing Mahayana influence, along with water tanks cut from the rock. B. Nasik is a Shaiva cave complex best known for Trimurti sculpture. C. Nasik belongs only to the Gupta period. D. Nasik has no relation to vihara development.

Answer: A. Explanation: A summarises the site's safest features from Nitin. The other options confuse Nasik with different sites or erase its typological value.

Q26. Which statement is NOT supported by the repaired source base?

A. Ajanta's cave count should not be the analytical point because unfinished or late-counted caves complicate simple totals. B. Elephanta's exact dynastic patronage is fully settled and should be stated without caution. C. Amaravati's lower Krishna location is a tested prelims discriminator. D. Hathigumpha is a major narrative source that still requires criticism.

Answer: B. Explanation: B is the unsupported statement because the source base repeatedly warns that Elephanta's precise attribution remains debated. The other three are positive controls from the repaired package.

Q27. Which UNESCO-year mapping is correct?

A. Sanchi 1983; Ajanta 1987; Ellora 1989; Elephanta 1991 B. Ajanta 1989; Ellora 1989; Sanchi 1983; Elephanta 1987 C. Ajanta 1983; Ellora 1983; Elephanta 1987; Sanchi 1989 D. Ajanta 1972; Ellora 1983; Elephanta 1989; Sanchi 1987

Answer: C. Explanation: C matches the official UNESCO listings used in the repaired package.

Q28. Which opening line best fits the verified 2020 GS-I rock-cut architecture question?

A. Rock-cut caves are beautiful tourist destinations and therefore important for history. B. Indian cave architecture is a long list of famous monuments from Bihar to Maharashtra. C. Because caves survive, they remove the need for source criticism. D. Rock-cut architecture is a major historical source because excavated form, inscription and long reuse preserve patronage, ritual plan and technical change more clearly than many perishable structures do.

Answer: D. Explanation: D is a real thesis, not a travel sentence. It defines why caves matter as sources and opens the way to named evidence plus limitation.

Q29. Which statement about the Baroda copper-plate is correct?

A. It refers to Elapura / Ellora and praises the Kailasha temple associated with Krishnaraja, giving rare textual corroboration for a surviving rock-cut monument. B. It is an Ashokan edict discovered at Barabar. C. It proves Elephanta's patronage beyond dispute. D. It is a Buddhist donor list from Ajanta.

Answer: A. Explanation: A is the correct use of the Baroda plate. The other options attach it to the wrong site, period or religious context.

Q30. Which statement on Mauryan polish is safest?

A. Mauryan polish continued unchanged as the normal finish for all later Indian stone sculpture. B. Mauryan polish is a real diagnostic feature of pillars and some cave interiors, but later decline should not be explained through one mechanically certain cause. C. Mauryan polish means that every Mauryan monument was built by Iranian craftsmen. D. Mauryan polish cannot be used in historical analysis.

Answer: B. Explanation: B keeps the feature while avoiding causal overclaim. A, C and D are all exaggerations.

Q31. Which question most directly tests site-identification rather than interpretation?

A. Discuss how sacred-site continuity can be inferred from Ellora. B. Examine the limits of royal inscriptions as historical sources. C. Which one of the following statements is correct? Ajanta Caves lie in the gorge of the Waghora river. D. How should Sanchi be used to explain layered patronage?

Answer: C. Explanation: C is a site-identification route, not a full monument-interpretation demand. The other options ask for analysis or argument.

Q32. Which comparison best summarises Topic 2 as a whole?

A. Mauryan, Buddhist, Jain and rock-cut heritage is basically a list of unrelated sites. B. The topic belongs entirely to philosophy because all architecture simply mirrors doctrine. C. The topic is only about Buddhism because Jain and Brahmanical caves are secondary. D. The topic traces how patronage, ritual function, inscription and long reuse turned stone monuments into layered records of early Indian art and history.

Answer: D. Explanation: D captures the repaired session's central thesis. The other options break the topic into false separations or crude reductions.

TIMELINE, KEYWORD AND PARAGRAPH-BUILDING DRILLS

Drill A - Ancient and modern timeline sorting

Task: Separate these cards into an ancient-development rail and a modern-recovery rail: Ashokan Sanchi core; Ajanta UNESCO 1983; Barabar-Nagarjuni; 1851 Cunningham survey of Sanchi; Kailasha under Krishna I; 1904-05 Oertel excavation of the Sarnath capital.

Solved answer:

- Ancient-development rail: Barabar-Nagarjuni -> Ashokan Sanchi core -> Kailasha under Krishna I.
- Modern-recovery rail: 1851 Cunningham survey of Sanchi -> 1904-05 Oertel excavation of the Sarnath capital -> Ajanta UNESCO 1983.

Drill B - Must-write keywords for the 2020 GS-I answer

Task: Pick six expressions that must appear in some form in a 150-word answer on rock-cut architecture as a historical source.

Solved answer: Barabar-Nagarjuni; chaitya-vihara distinction; Ajanta or Ellora phase evidence; inscription / donor record; Hathigumpha or Baroda plate; durable patronage bias.

Drill C - Build one paragraph from notes

Task notes: Ajivika dedication; apsidal chaitya; Hathigumpha omission; durable stone.

Model paragraph: Rock-cut architecture is a major historical source because it preserves both excavated form and inscriptional context. The Barabar-Nagarjuni caves show royal dedication to Ajivika ascetics, proving that Mauryan

rock-cut patronage cannot be reduced to Buddhism alone. The apsidal chaitya form then allows later caves to be read through ritual function rather than mere shape. Yet inscriptions themselves remain selective, as Hathigumpha's silence on the Mauryan invasion of Kalinga reminds us. Thus caves preserve durable patronage and ritual space exceptionally well, but they cannot by themselves stand for the whole of early Indian social life.

Drill D - Site-identity firewall

Task: Match the site to the one discriminator that actually wins an objective question: Ajanta; Elephanta; Amaravati; Udayagiri (Vidisha); Udayagiri-Khandagiri.

Solved answer:

- Ajanta -> Waghora gorge and two-phase Buddhist cave complex.
- Elephanta -> Gharapuri island and Sadashiva / Trimurti.
- Amaravati -> lower Krishna / Guntur and Mahachaitya with Ayaka-pillars.
- Udayagiri (Vidisha) -> Chandragupta II, Varaha and Gupta inscriptions.
- Udayagiri-Khandagiri -> Kharavela, Hathigumpha and Jain twin hills near Bhubaneswar.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

DIRECT OWNED PYQ - 2020 GS-I Q1

Ownership: Direct owner - Indian Art and Culture Topic 02. **Status:** Official printed Mains question already repository-verified from the locally held UPSC paper in adjacent validated packages.

Question: The rock-cut architecture represents one of the most important sources of our knowledge of early Indian art and history. Discuss. (Answer in 150 words)

Examiner-ready model answer: Rock-cut architecture is a major source for early Indian art and history because excavated monuments preserve patronage, ritual plan, technical skill and inscriptions in one durable record. The Barabar and Nagarjuni caves, dedicated by Ashoka and Dasharatha to the Ajivikas, show that early rock-cut architecture already recorded royal support to a heterodox sect. Later chaityas and viharas reveal religious practice through plan: apsidal worship halls differ clearly from residential monastic spaces. Sites such as Ajanta and Ellora also preserve long chronological phases, allowing historians to trace change in Buddhist, Brahmanical and Jain patronage. Inscriptions sharpen the evidence further: Hathigumpha anchors Kharavela's Jain context, while the Baroda copper-plate helps corroborate Ellora's Kailasha. Yet the evidence has limits. Rock-cut monuments over-represent what was endowed in durable stone and must be read critically alongside inscriptional silence, textual genre and non-surviving perishable architecture.

Why this earns marks: It answers the word 'source', not merely the word 'architecture'; it uses named sites for different evidentiary jobs and ends with a real methodological limit.

APPLICATION PYQ - 2021 Prelims GS-I Q49

Ownership: Topic 02 direct application PYQ. **Status:** The location statement and answer letter are locally verified through the source's reproduced question and key.

Question: Which one of the following statements is correct?

- A. Ajanta Caves lie in the gorge of the Waghora river.
- B. Sanchi Stupa lies in the gorge of the Chambal River.
- C. Pandavleni Caves lie in the gorge of the Narmada River.
- D. Amaravati Stupa lies in the gorge of the Godavari River.

Answer: A - verified through the source's reproduced answer key.

Solved logic:

- Ajanta is the Waghora-gorge site in the Sahyadri hills.
- Sanchi is a hilltop Buddhist complex near Vidisha, not a Chambal gorge site.
- Pandavleni/Nasik is a hill cave complex, not the Narmada gorge.

- Amaravati lies in the lower Krishna-Guntur zone, not the Godavari gorge.

Why this earns marks: It treats the question as a site-identifier problem and eliminates each distractor with one geography fact.

VERIFICATION-PENDING PYQs

2023 Prelims GS-I Q42

Ownership: Topic 02 direct application PYQ. **Status:** Official question verified locally; official UPSC key unavailable locally. **Answer withheld pending official UPSC key.**

Question: With reference to ancient India, consider: (1) the concept of Stupa is Buddhist in origin; (2) Stupa was generally a repository of relics; (3) Stupa was a votive and commemorative structure in Buddhist tradition. How many statements are correct?

- A. Only one
- B. Only two
- C. All three
- D. None

Verification note: Answer withheld pending official UPSC key.

Concept analysis:

- Recheck the distinction between pre-Buddhist origin and later Buddhist elaboration of the stupa.
- Keep relic-repository and votive / commemorative roles conceptually separate while revising.
- Use the topic's core rule: do not convert the stupa into an exclusively Buddhist origin-form.

2023 Prelims GS-I Q82

Ownership: Topic 02 direct application PYQ with Topic 07 cross-link for Sittanavasal's painting context. **Status:** Exact wording verified through reliable reproductions; official UPSC key unavailable locally. **Answer withheld pending official UPSC key.**

Question: Consider the following pairs:

Site	Well known for
1. Besnagar	Shaivite cave shrine
2. Bhaja	Buddhist cave shrine
3. Sittanavasal	Jain cave shrine

How many of the above pairs are correctly matched?

- A. Only one
- B. Only two
- C. All three
- D. None

Verification note: Answer withheld pending official UPSC key.

Concept analysis:

- Anchor Bhaja in the western Deccan Buddhist cave chain used for chaitya-vihara development.
- Keep Sittanavasal in the Jain cave-shrine tradition, with mural detail mainly cross-owned by Topic 07.
- Recheck Besnagar through its Heliodorus / Vidisha context instead of guessing from the word 'shrine'.

2026 Prelims GS-I Q13

Ownership: Topic 02 direct application PYQ with Ancient History cross-link for Dhanyakataka / lower-Krishna context. **Status:** Question wording verified locally; a locally held provisional key exists but is not treated here as final or official. **Answer withheld pending official UPSC key.**

Question: Which statements on the Amaravati Stupa and its relief sculpture are correct?

1. It was located in the lower Krishna valley.
 2. In India, it was next only to the Sanchi Stupa in size.
 3. The Amaravati school made a lasting impact on later South Indian sculpture, and its products were carried to Sri Lanka and Southeast Asia.
- A. 2 and 3 only
 - B. 1 only
 - C. 1 and 3 only
 - D. 1, 2 and 3

Verification note: Answer withheld pending official UPSC key.

Concept analysis:

- Keep Amaravati fixed in the lower Krishna / Guntur / Dhanyakataka-Dharanikota context.
- Treat size claims cautiously and do not convert a source hedge into false precision.
- Revise artistic influence separately from any assumption of political control over Sri Lanka or Southeast Asia.

ORIGINAL MAINS 1 - 10 MARKS

Question: Discuss Ashokan pillars as instruments of imperial art and communication. Answer in about 150 words.

Examiner-ready model answer: Ashokan pillars are one of the clearest expressions of Mauryan court art because they combine standardised form with site-specific messaging. Nitin describes them as monolithic Chunar-sandstone shafts, often around 40 feet high, carrying lotus- or bell-shaped capitals, abaci and animal figures. This standardisation itself is political: a recognisable visual language could travel across the empire. Yet the pillars were not mechanically identical. The Sarnath capital uses four lions on a richly symbolic abacus and later became India's National Emblem, while the Vaishali pillar uses a single lion without an abacus and the Sanchi pillar carries the Schism Edict with a different decorative programme. Their importance lies in joining sculpture, inscription and sacred geography. They show imperial presence at important sites and preserve ideological messages in durable stone. At the same time, they should not be reduced to ornament; they were instruments of communication with local variation built into the Mauryan system.

Why this earns marks: It treats pillars as a communication system, uses comparison across sites and avoids describing one capital as if it stood for all pillars.

ORIGINAL MAINS 2 - 10 MARKS

Question: Distinguish a chaitya from a vihara and explain why the distinction matters. Answer in about 150 words.

Examiner-ready model answer: A chaitya and a vihara are different architectural responses to different religious needs. A chaitya is primarily a prayer or assembly hall. In rock-cut examples it often has an apsidal end, a central nave, side aisles, a horseshoe-shaped facade opening and a stupa at the terminal focus. A vihara, by contrast, is a residential and monastic space organised around halls and cells for monks. The distinction matters because early Indian cave architecture can be interpreted correctly only when function is read from plan. At sites such as Ajanta and Nasik, this difference helps historians distinguish congregational worship from monastic residence. It also prevents a common UPSC error of using the two terms interchangeably. Once the plans are separated, the monuments become evidence of religious practice, not just cave shapes. Thus the chaitya-vihara distinction is not merely vocabulary; it is the key to reading cave architecture as social and ritual history.

Why this earns marks: It defines both forms, links plan to practice and explains why the distinction matters analytically.

ORIGINAL MAINS 3 - 15 MARKS

Question: Trace the evolution of the Buddhist stupa from Mauryan beginnings to post-Mauryan elaboration, using Sanchi and Amaravati. Answer in about 250 words.

Examiner-ready model answer: The Buddhist stupa evolved by elaboration around a stable ritual core. Its deepest background is pre-Buddhist, but in Buddhist tradition it became a relic-bearing, votive and commemorative structure. The core architectural idea remained the same: an anda or mound marking relic presence, structured by the vedika, pradakshina patha, harmika and chattra. What changed over time was scale, material and narrative surface.

At Sanchi, the evolution is unusually clear. The Great Stupa began as an Ashokan brick hemisphere. In the Sunga period it was enlarged, faced with stone and given a developed ambulatory, railing and harmika. In the Satavahana phase, the four toranas became major sculptural and narrative thresholds. Gupta additions later extended the site's life beyond its Mauryan origin. Sanchi therefore demonstrates accretion across dynasties rather than one moment of creation.

Amaravati shows a different direction of elaboration. In the lower Krishna region, the Mahachaitya became associated with ornate limestone reliefs, cardinal Ayaka-pillars and a strong Satavahana-Andhra phase of growth. Its significance lies in linking stupa architecture with sculptural schools, inscriptions and trans-regional artistic influence.

Thus, the Buddhist stupa evolved not by abandoning its relic-centred core, but by accumulating railings, gateways, reliefs and regional idioms that turned one sacred form into many historically layered monuments.

Why this earns marks: It explains continuity and change together and uses Sanchi and Amaravati for different regional styles of elaboration.

ORIGINAL MAINS 4 - 15 MARKS

Question: How should inscriptions be used to interpret early Indian monuments? Answer in about 250 words.

Examiner-ready model answer: Inscriptions are among the most valuable aids to interpreting early Indian monuments, but they are strongest when used critically rather than literally. Their first contribution is precision. They can identify patrons, sects, dates, grants, sacred geographies and sometimes even the reason for endowment. For architecture, this means that a monument is no longer read only through style or plan. The Barabar and Nagarjuni dedications tie the earliest rock-cut caves directly to Ashoka, Dasharatha and the Ajivikas. The Sanchi Schism Edict links a major pillar to monastic discipline, while the Baroda copper-plate corroborates the fame of Elapura and the Kailasha temple.

However, inscriptions are not neutral mirrors. Upinder Singh's broader method is useful here: royal inscriptions are genre-bound texts. Hathigumpha is the classic example in this topic. It is the principal narrative source for Kharavela, but it is also commemorative and selective, famously omitting the Mauryan invasion of Kalinga. Such silence does not make the inscription useless; instead, it reveals the need for source criticism.

Therefore, inscriptions should be used in three stages: first to anchor patronage and chronology, second to corroborate architectural interpretation, and third to identify bias, omission and eulogistic exaggeration. Read this way, inscriptions deepen monument history; read uncritically, they distort it.

Why this earns marks: It gives both the positive use and the methodological limit, which is exactly what a good history answer requires.

ORIGINAL MAINS 5 - 20 MARKS

Question: Examine how rock-cut monuments reveal patronage, religious change and technical skill from the Mauryan age to the early medieval period. Answer in about 300 words.

Examiner-ready model answer: Rock-cut monuments are among the richest material records for early Indian history because they reveal who endowed sacred space, how communities used it and how technical ambition expanded over time. The Mauryan phase begins with the Barabar and Nagarjuni caves. Their polished granite interiors, inscriptional dedications and Ajivika affiliation show that royal patronage to heterodox groups was already being expressed through permanent excavation. This stage also preserves the translation of wooden architectural forms into stone, most clearly at Lomas Rishi.

In the post-Mauryan and early historic centuries, Buddhist cave architecture became more differentiated. The chaitya-vihara distinction makes plan readable as practice: apsidal worship halls with stupa focus differ from residential monastic cells. Western Deccan sites such as Bhaja, Karle and Nasik show this development in relation to route societies, donors and monastic expansion. Ajanta adds an even larger historical value, because its two major phases preserve change from early austere and often aniconic caves to later image-rich Mahayana spaces with extensive painting and facade decoration.

The Gupta and early-medieval phase widens the field further. Udayagiri near Vidisha links Brahmanical myth, royal inscription and cave-shrine planning. Elephanta foregrounds Shaiva iconography in a major island cave-temple. Ellora, finally, preserves Buddhist, Brahmanical and Jain groups across centuries, culminating in the monolithic Kailasha. The Baroda copper-plate and other inscriptions help anchor these monuments historically.

Yet a good answer must add one limit: rock-cut monuments preserve durable patronage exceptionally well, but they over-represent what was excavated in stone and cannot alone stand for the whole of early Indian social life.

Why this earns marks: It is fully phased, uses examples for different evidentiary jobs and ends with the crucial source-limit sentence.

ORIGINAL MAINS 6 - 20 MARKS

Question: Compare Buddhist, Jain and Brahmanical uses of rock-cut space in early India. Answer in about 300 words.

Examiner-ready model answer: Buddhist, Jain and Brahmanical traditions all used rock-cut space, but they did so for partly different sacred purposes and at different historical moments. The Buddhist use is the clearest in typological terms. Chaityas organised congregational worship around the stupa, while viharas organised residence and monastic life. Sites such as Bhaja, Nasik and Ajanta therefore preserve both liturgical form and monastic institution. Ajanta's two phases further show how Buddhist rock-cut space moved from early austere and often symbolic worship environments to later image-rich Mahayana cave complexes.

Jain use of rock-cut space is strongly visible at Udayagiri-Khandagiri in Odisha, where Kharavela's patronage, Hathigumpha's inscription and the dwelling-meditation function of caves create a different sacred environment. Later Jain caves at Ellora and Badami widen the tradition, but a broader Jain architectural answer must move beyond caves to temple, colossus and pilgrimage-hill forms such as Dilwara, Shravanabelagola and Shatrunjaya.

Brahmanical cave use becomes especially prominent in the Gupta and early-medieval period. Udayagiri near Vidisha turns the cave into a medium of royal mythology and inscription, while Elephanta creates a Shaiva cave-temple centred on the Sadashiva image and linga shrine. Ellora's Brahmanical phase reaches a technical climax in the monolithic Kailasha temple.

The common thread is that rock-cut space offered permanence and dramatic sacred setting. The difference lies in emphasis: Buddhist plans highlight monastic and congregational function, Jain programmes stress ascetic and pilgrimage settings, and Brahmanical caves intensify image, myth and sanctum-centred sacred presence.

Why this earns marks: It compares the three traditions through function and sacred use rather than merely listing sites under separate religious headings.